

Signoff: Business Proposal & Architecture

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Executive summary

Signoff is a chat-first operating system for a one-person or very small US business. The founder describes what they want to do, and a Claude-powered agent walks them, in order, through forming the company, getting an EIN, opening a bank account, connecting accounting, email and travel, and finding a CPA at tax time. Everything the founder can type is backed by a fixed set of tools; the agent decides what to say, a deterministic workflow engine decides what step comes next, and a policy gate decides what is allowed.

The product looks like a plain chatbot with a thin sidebar: KYC, Bank, Email, Accounting, Taxes, and a user icon for settings. The sidebar is not navigation so much as a status board: each item shows whether that part of the business is set up, and clicking it drops the right context into the chat.

Two design choices make the business defensible and keep us out of regulated territory. First, Signoff never holds money, never verifies identity for a bank, and never signs a tax return; the bank runs KYC, the CPA signs, and payments are executed by the bank under the owner's own approval. Second, Signoff owns the orchestration layer (the memory of the business, the compliance calendar, the step-by-step guidance) and rents everything else through partner APIs. That layer is the moat; the connectors are commodities.

Revenue comes from three places: a formation package, a monthly subscription for the agent, and partner revenue (bank referral bounties, travel margin, accounting-software affiliate and CPA referral fees). The lean path to launch needs no banking licence, no BaaS contract and no capital raise: a formation partner, a bank referral agreement, QuickBooks and Gmail/Microsoft OAuth apps, and Claude.

The problem

A first-time founder has to complete roughly a dozen unrelated tasks in the first 90 days, each in a different product with a different login, and nobody tells them the order. Formation sites stop at the certificate. Banks stop at the account. Accounting software assumes the books already exist. Email, travel and presentations live in general-purpose tools that know nothing about the business.

The tasks, in the order they actually have to happen:

1. Decide the entity type and state (LLC vs. corporation; home state vs. Delaware or Wyoming).
2. Form the entity and appoint a registered agent.
3. Get an EIN from the IRS.
4. Adopt an operating agreement or bylaws (the bank will ask).
5. Open a business bank account and a card.
6. Set up accounting and connect the bank feed.
7. Set up a business email on the company domain.
8. Issue the first invoice and get paid.
9. Pay the first vendor.
10. Track deductible spend, including travel.
11. Register for state taxes, sales tax or payroll if they apply.
12. Find a CPA before the first filing deadline.

Today the founder stitches this together from blog posts and the bank's checklist. Each product solves its own step well and hands off badly. The gap Signoff fills is the hand-off: one place that knows what has been done, what is next, and can do the next thing for you, or at least prepare it so you only have to say yes.

Competitive landscape

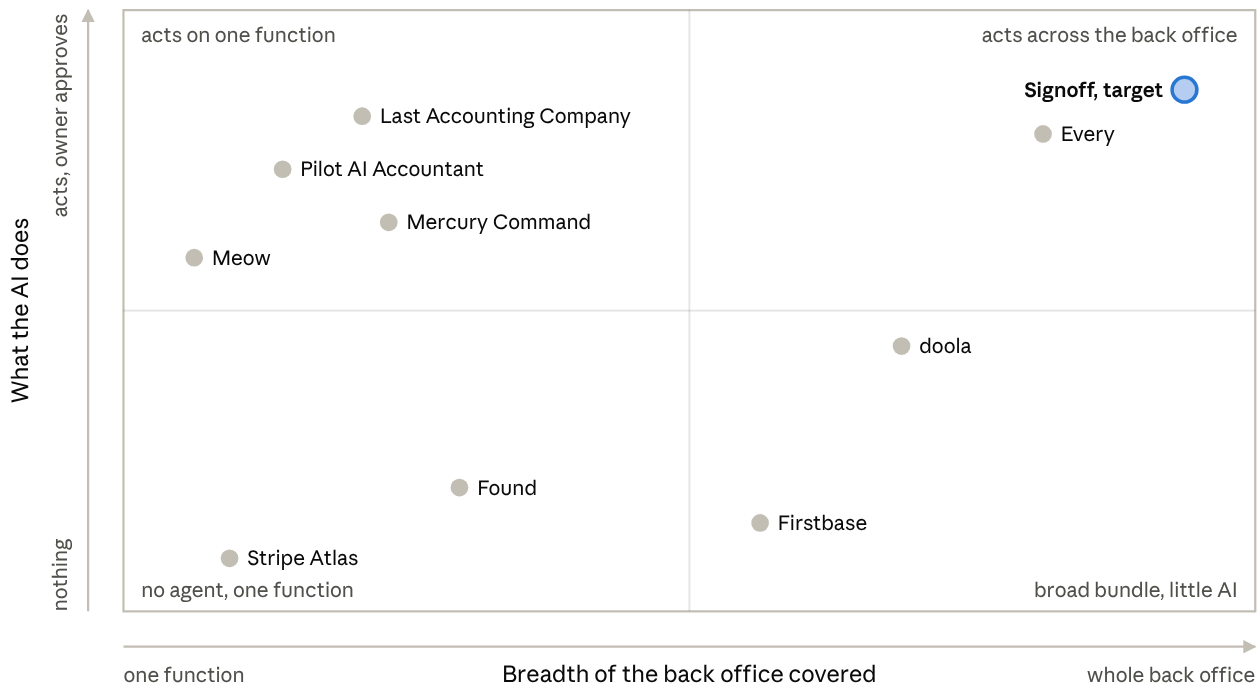
Nobody sells the whole chain in one chat yet, but every link has a well-funded owner, and in 2026 three of them (Every, doola, Mercury) started moving toward the others. The open ground is the hand-off: a conversation that starts from what the founder wants to do and carries them across formation, bank, books, email and taxes without owning any of those pieces. Checked on 2026-10-03; prices are list prices from the vendors' own pages on that date.

Company	Starts from	Covers	What the AI does	Price	Missing against Signoff
Every	Payroll and HR	Incorporation, banking, payroll, benefits, HR, accounting, taxes in one platform	AI CFO, AI Bookkeeper, AI CHRO announced 13 Mar 2026; agents act with full back-office context	Not disclosed	Email, travel, presentations; it owns the regulated stack we deliberately rent
doola	Formation	LLC filing, EIN, registered agent, bookkeeping, tax filing, CPA consults, e-commerce analytics; bank account by introduction	"AI Co-Founder" answers questions 24/7; it does not take actions	Starter \$297/yr; Tax & Compliance \$1,999/yr; Business-in-a-Box \$2,999/yr or \$329/mo	An agent that does things; bank, email, payments, travel
Mercury Command	The bank account	Banking, cards, invoices, transaction categorisation, with 300,000+ customers	Conversational assistant rolled out June 2026; every action is staged and the owner approves before it runs	Included with the account	Formation, books, taxes, email; it can only see the bank's slice of the business
Meow	The bank account, for agents	Checking, cards, ACH and wires, invoicing, exposed to any AI tool through MCP (live 9 Apr 2026)	Any agent (Claude, ChatGPT, Cursor) can request; the owner approves by link; caps and toggles by default	Account with no minimum balance	Everything outside banking; it is infrastructure, and a candidate bank partner rather than a rival
Firstbase	Formation	Formation, accrual bookkeeping, registered agent, virtual mailroom, tax filing, sales tax, banking marketplace	Name and mission-statement generators only	Formation "pay only your state fee" offer; bundle prices not shown on the page	Any agent; bank, email, payments, travel

Company	Starts from	Covers	What the AI does	Price	Missing against Signoff
Stripe Atlas	Formation for venture-track startups	Delaware incorporation, EIN, founder equity, 83(b), templates, Stripe credits, Stripe Treasury banking	None	\$500 one-time, then \$100/yr registered agent	Everything after incorporation; not a law firm, no bookkeeping
Found	The bank account, for solopreneurs	Checking, bookkeeping, tax estimates and payments, invoicing	Automated categorisation and write-off detection, no chat agent	Free; Plus \$35/mo; Pro \$80/mo	Formation, email, travel, a CPA path
Pilot AI Accountant	The ledger	Onboarding, categorisation, reconciliation, historical close, monthly statements, with a transaction-level audit trail (announced 4 Feb 2026)	Fully autonomous bookkeeping, chat for questions	Not stated on the page	Formation, bank, email, payments; a candidate partner for the Accounting module
Last Accounting Company	The ledger, as a firm	Bookkeeping, invoices, payroll, receipts, filings on a proprietary ledger; founders ask questions through Slack	Agents do the work, a certified accountant signs off (YC Summer 2026)	Not stated	Formation, bank, email, travel; replaces QuickBooks rather than wrapping it

QuickBooks and Xero are also adding agents inside their own products, which strengthens the case for wrapping them rather than replacing them.

Only Every and Signoff aim at a broad back office where the AI acts



competitor map · breadth vs. what the AI does · 9 companies and Signoff

Positions are our reading of each company's own pages in the table above, not a measured score. The left column is crowded with agents that act on one function; the right column has one shipping product and Signoff.

What this means for Signoff:

- **The direct threat is Every.** Same thesis, same "agents with full context" language, already shipping. The difference is structural: Every owns banking and payroll, which is a regulated, capital-heavy stack. Signoff rents all of it and competes on the conversation and the hand-offs. That is cheaper to build and easier to switch partners under, but it is not a moat by itself; the moat has to be the guided journey and the memory of the business.
- **doola proves the bundle sells.** A \$329-a-month "Business-in-a-Box" with a human bookkeeper tells us founders will pay for one place that handles it all. doola's AI answers questions and does nothing, which is exactly the step Signoff takes next.
- **Mercury is the one to watch, not fight.** It has the customers and it has already built the pattern Signoff needs: the AI is read-only, and anything that moves money goes through a separate deterministic service the owner clicks to approve. If Mercury adds formation, it closes most of the gap. The better move is to make Mercury or Meow the bank partner so that pattern is ours by API.

- **Accounting agents are partners.** Pilot and Last Accounting Company want the ledger; Signoff wants the owner. A "books by Pilot" option inside the Accounting module is cheaper than building categorisation ourselves.
- **Pricing is in range.** Signoff's \$249 formation sits under Atlas and near doola; \$39 and \$99 a month sit beside Found's \$35 and \$80 while covering more. The formation fee should not be the profit centre; the subscription and the bank referral should.
- **Nobody does email, travel or presentations.** These are the cheapest parts to add and the ones that make the product feel like a chief of staff rather than a finance tool. They are also the least defensible, so they belong in the subscription as reasons to stay, not as the pitch.

The product

Signoff is one chat window with a five-item sidebar and a settings icon. The chat is where everything happens. The sidebar shows the state of the business and scopes what the agent is allowed to do.

Sidebar item	What it shows	What the agent can do there	Tools behind it
KYC	Owner identity status, company status (not formed / filed / active), documents on file, next compliance date	Collect business description, confirm it is a legal business, pick entity and state, file formation, apply for EIN, store the certificate and the IRS letter, run periodic re-checks	Identity-verification vendor, formation partner API, IRS Form SS-4 as third-party designee, document vault
Bank	Account status (not opened / pending at bank / open), balance, recent transactions, pending payments awaiting approval	Hand formation documents to the bank, track application, read balances and transactions, draft a payment for the owner to approve, order a card	Bank partner API (referral + data + payment initiation), Plaid as read-only fallback

Sidebar item	What it shows	What the agent can do there	Tools behind it
Email	Connected mailboxes, unread count, drafts the agent prepared	Read, search, summarise, draft and send email on Gmail or Outlook; later, a native mailbox on the company domain	Gmail API, Microsoft Graph, later a provisioned Google Workspace or Microsoft 365 seat
Accounting	Books status (connected / unreconciled items / last close), invoices outstanding, cash position	Connect QuickBooks or Xero, create and send invoices, categorise transactions, chase late payers, export reports, book travel and file the receipt against the trip	QuickBooks Online API, Xero API, travel API (Duffel or similar), presentation generator
Taxes	Compliance calendar, estimated-tax reminders, CPA match status, tax package readiness	Keep the calendar (franchise tax, annual report, estimated payments, 1099s), prepare the year-end package from the books, match the owner to a CPA, hand off and track the filing	Calendar engine, CPA network, document vault
Settings (user icon)	Profile, phone for OTP, connected accounts, spend limits, plan and usage	Change limits, disconnect services, export data, delete account	Auth service, policy store

The chat accepts any request the tools can serve. Anything outside the tool set gets a plain answer and, where relevant, a nudge back to the next unfinished step.

Presentations, invoices and emails are produced as files or drafts inside the chat with a Send or Approve card; nothing leaves the system without a click.

Visual theme: dark blue and black (decided 2026-10-03). The app is dark by default, in the register of a bank's app rather than a chat toy. Flat surfaces, no gradients, no glows, no glass.

Role	Colour	Where it is used
Page background	Black, #0A0C10	Behind everything
Surfaces (sidebar, cards, inputs)	Dark navy, #0F1B33	Sidebar, approval cards, message bubbles from the agent
Raised surface and borders	Navy, #16264A	Hover states, card borders, dividers
Primary text	Off-white, #E8ECF4	All body text
Secondary text	Slate, #9AA7C2	Timestamps, hints, sidebar status lines
Accent	Signal blue, #3B7BFF	Approve buttons, the active sidebar item, links, the OTP card
Good / warning / critical	#2FBF71, #F2B134, #E5484D	Sidebar status dots (set up / pending / blocked), payment warnings

One accent only, used for the thing the owner should tap next. Status colours appear as small dots beside sidebar items, never as coloured panels. Typography is the system font (SF Pro on Apple, Segoe on Windows, Roboto on Android) at 15px body, with the serif reserved for nothing. A light theme is a later setting, not a launch requirement.

Three interaction rules keep it simple:

- One active step at a time. The agent always knows the next unfinished item and offers it when the conversation idles.
- Approve cards, not free-text confirmations. Money movement, sending email and filing documents all end in a structured card the owner taps. Payments add a one-time code.
- The sidebar is the truth. Status comes from webhooks and polling of the partner systems, not from what the model believes.

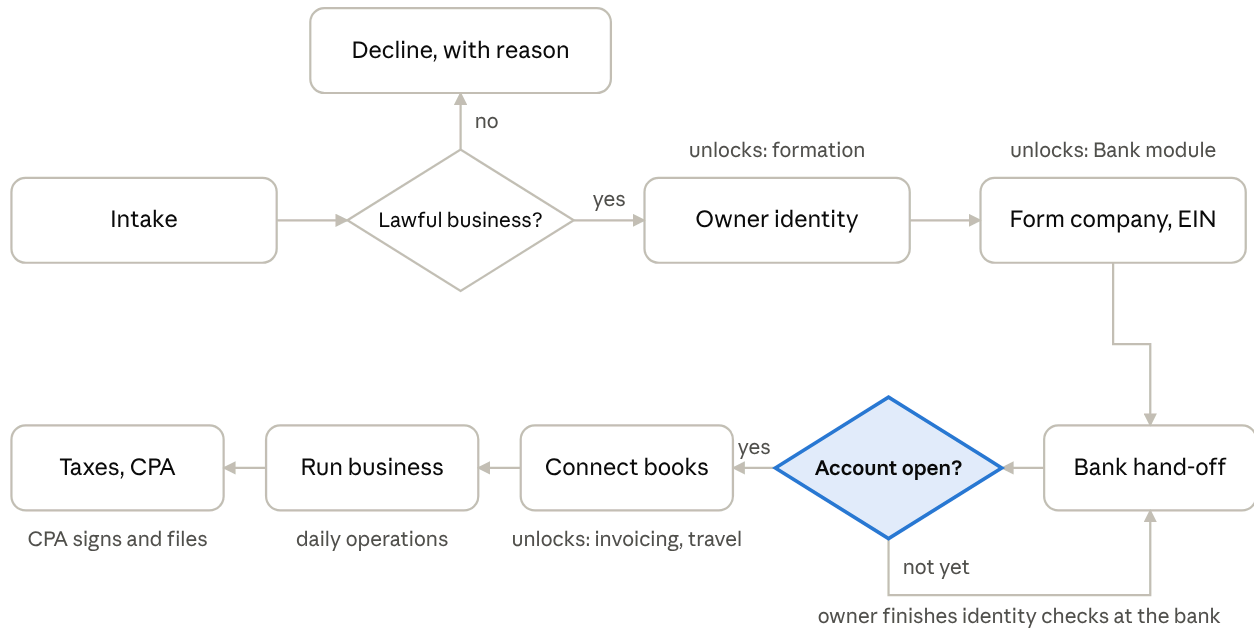
The guided journey

The conversation is channelled. The owner can ask anything, but the agent always has a current stage, and tools unlock as gates are passed. The stages, and what each one unlocks:

1. **Intake.** The owner describes what they want to do in their own words. The agent restates it as a one-line business description, asks the three or four questions that matter (where you live, will you have partners, will you sell online, will you hire), and checks the description against an allowed-activity list. Gate 1: it is a lawful business we can serve. Prohibited or high-risk categories (money services, gambling, adult, cannabis, weapons, crypto exchange) are declined up front, politely, with a reason.
2. **Owner identity.** Phone OTP to create the account, then a light identity check (government ID plus selfie through a vendor such as Persona or Stripe Identity) and a sanctions screen on the name. This is for us, not for the bank. Unlocks: formation.
3. **Form the company.** The agent recommends entity type and state with a short why, drafts the filing, and submits it through the formation partner. It also produces the operating agreement or bylaws because the bank will ask for them. When the state returns the certificate, the agent applies for the EIN. Unlocks: Bank module.
4. **Open the bank account.** The agent pre-fills the bank application and pushes the certificate, EIN letter and operating agreement directly to the bank partner. The owner finishes at the bank: ID, selfie, beneficial-owner questions, signatures. We never see or store their ID for the bank. Gate 2: bank confirms the account is open (webhook). Unlocks: balances, transactions, card, payment drafting, and the Accounting module.
5. **Connect the books.** OAuth to QuickBooks Online or Xero, or a new QuickBooks subscription through our affiliate link. The bank feed connects inside QuickBooks. Gate 3: books connected. Unlocks: invoicing, categorisation, travel booking with receipt capture, tax package preparation.
6. **Connect email.** OAuth to Gmail or Microsoft 365. Unlocks: read, draft, send, and the chase-late-invoice flow.
7. **Run the business.** Invoices, payments (drafted by the agent, approved by the owner with a one-time code, executed by the bank), travel, presentations, email. The compliance calendar runs in the background and raises items in chat.
8. **Taxes.** Ninety days before the first deadline the agent closes the books with the owner, assembles the tax package, and matches a CPA. The CPA files. The agent tracks acceptance and stores the return.

Every stage can be skipped if the owner already has that piece (an existing company, an existing bank). In that case the agent asks for the document or connection instead of creating it, and the gate is passed by verification rather than by creation.

Tools unlock only after the bank confirms the account



guided journey · 8 stages, 2 gates

The first gate keeps prohibited businesses out before anything is filed. The second is the one that matters: payments, cards and the Accounting module exist only after the bank's webhook says the account is open, and they disappear again if it closes.

Trust and KYC strategy

The principle is right: let the bank do the heavy identity work, and treat the bank's confirmation as the gate that unlocks anything touching money. The mechanism needs one change. We should not withhold the certificate or the EIN from the owner. We should deliver both to the owner and to the bank at the same time, and make the bank's "account open" event the gate.

Why withholding does not work:

- The certificate of formation is a public record. Anyone can pull it from the Secretary of State for a few dollars, so holding it back protects nothing.

- The EIN belongs to the entity. When we apply as third-party designee on Form SS-4, our authority ends when the IRS issues the number, and we are expected to hand it over. Keeping it would be a complaint waiting to happen.
- The bank's KYC is for the bank. Under the Customer Identification Program rules a bank may rely on another regulated financial institution, never on a software company, and it does not share its KYC file with us. So the bank verifying the owner does not transfer any duty off us; it simply gives us a strong, observable signal.
- Holding a founder's company hostage is a trust problem in a product whose whole pitch is trust.

What the bank's confirmation does give us is valuable: a regulated institution has run document verification, selfie match, beneficial-ownership collection and sanctions screening on this person and this company, and will keep monitoring transactions. We consume that as a webhook and unlock payment drafting, card ordering and transaction access only after it arrives. If the bank later closes the account, the same webhook locks those tools.

What we still verify ourselves, because we are the ones forming companies and sending payment instructions in our name:

Check	Who does it	When	Why we need it even with the bank
Phone OTP	Signoff	Account creation, every login, every payment approval	Ties every action to a device the owner holds
Light identity (ID + selfie)	Signoff via a vendor (Persona, Stripe Identity or Alloy)	Before we file anything	Stops bulk shell-company creation through our formation tool; also fraud protection for the formation fee
Sanctions screen (OFAC and consolidated lists)	Signoff via the same vendor	At signup, then quarterly, and on any name or ownership change	OFAC applies to every US business, not just banks

Check	Who does it	When	Why we need it even with the bank
Allowed-activity screen	Signoff (model plus a fixed list)	Intake, and annually ("is this still what you do?")	Keeps prohibited and high-risk categories out before we have spent anything on them
Full CIP, beneficial ownership (FinCEN CDD rule), ongoing transaction monitoring	Bank	Account opening and continuously	Legally theirs; we never collect SSNs, IDs or ownership percentages for the bank
Good-standing check with the state	Signoff	Quarterly	Feeds the Taxes calendar and catches a lapsed company before it tries to transact
Device and session anomalies	Signoff	Continuous	New device, new country or velocity spikes force a fresh OTP and pause money tools

In person or remote. The founder's idea of in-person KYC at a branch is possible with a traditional bank, but traditional banks offer no API for referral, document hand-off or payment initiation. Fintech business banks (Mercury, Relay, Brex, Novo and similar) do all of their KYC remotely and do offer partner programmes and APIs. Recommendation: start with one fintech bank partner for the integrated path, and offer a "bring your own bank" path where the owner opens an account anywhere and connects it read-only through Plaid. The read-only path never unlocks payment drafting.

Periodic monitoring is a calendar, not a department. Every check in the table has a next-run date stored per company. The workflow engine runs it, a vendor returns a result, and only exceptions reach a human reviewer. For a one-person company the whole ongoing cost of this is a few vendor calls a year.

Beneficial-ownership reporting to FinCEN under the Corporate Transparency Act was suspended for US-formed companies in March 2025. We should not build it now, but the Taxes calendar should carry a watch item in case the rule returns.

Wrapper or owner: domain by domain

We own three things: the memory of the business, the order of operations, and the approval surface. Everything else is rented. The test for each domain is whether owning it adds trust or margin we cannot get otherwise. Partner names below are candidates to diligence, not decisions; each needs a partner agreement and a check of what its API actually permits.

Domain	Our role	How it feels to the owner	Candidate partners	What we abstract away
Formation and registered agent	Wrapper with a strong opinion	"Form my LLC in Wyoming" becomes a filled filing, an operating agreement, and a tracked state submission	Formation and registered-agent providers with partner APIs (Firstbase, Doola, Harbor Compliance, Northwest); fall back to filing directly with the state for the first two or three states we support	State forms, registered-agent appointment, publication requirements, EIN application via Form SS-4

Domain	Our role	How it feels to the owner	Candidate partners	What we abstract away
Bank	Referral plus integration, never custody	Documents arrive at the bank before the owner does; balances and payment drafts appear in chat	One fintech business bank with referral programme and API (Mercury, Relay, Brex); Plaid for read-only bring-your-own-bank	Application pre-fill, status tracking, payment formatting, approval hand-off
Payments	Instruction drafting only	"Pay the designer \$1,200" becomes a card with payee, amount, memo and a one-time code; the bank executes and may require its own second approval	The bank partner's payment API	Payee lookup from invoices and email, ACH vs. wire choice, memo text, duplicate detection
Accounting	Thin wrapper	Books stay in QuickBooks; the owner never opens it unless they want to	QuickBooks Online API (primary), Xero API (second)	Categorisation suggestions, reconciliation prompts, invoice creation and sending, report pulls
Invoicing	Wrapper over the accounting system	"Invoice Acme \$4,000 for September, net 30" becomes a sent QuickBooks invoice with a payment link	QuickBooks Payments or Stripe Invoicing behind the QuickBooks invoice	Customer records, line items, tax lines, reminders, late-payer chasing by email

Domain	Our role	How it feels to the owner	Candidate partners	What we abstract away
Email	Wrapper now, client later	Read, summarise, draft and send inside chat; the owner's mail stays in Gmail or Outlook	Gmail API, Microsoft Graph; or a unified-mail API (Nylas) if we want one integration instead of two	OAuth, threading, attachments, scheduling, tone; see the next section for the native-mailbox plan
Travel	Wrapper with policy	"Book me to Austin Tuesday, back Thursday, under \$600" becomes two or three options and a receipt filed to the trip	Duffel (flights and stays) or Spotnana; pay with the company card from the bank partner	Fare rules, change fees, receipt capture, expense categorisation
Presentations and documents	Owned generation	"Make a 6-slide pitch for the landscaping business" becomes a downloadable file in brand colours	Our own generator (python-pptx or an equivalent), optional Google Slides export	Layout, structure, consistency with the business profile
CPA and taxes	Marketplace plus preparation	Books are closed and the package is ready; a matched CPA accepts the engagement in chat; the CPA signs and files	A curated CPA network with a referral agreement; later an API partner such as a tax-prep platform	Compliance calendar, estimated-tax maths, 1099 collection, package assembly, deadline tracking

Domain	Our role	How it feels to the owner	Candidate partners	What we abstract away
Identity and compliance checks	Wrapper	Invisible when it passes	Persona, Stripe Identity or Alloy; a sanctions-screening API	Vendor orchestration, re-screen schedule, exception queue

Two domains deserve a note.

Banking could later move from referral to embedded banking (a BaaS provider such as Unit, Treasury Prime or Increase with a sponsor bank). That gives us interchange and a branded account, but it also makes us the programme manager with a written BSA/AML programme, a compliance officer and sponsor-bank audits. It is a reasonable Phase 3 once there are thousands of accounts. It is the wrong Phase 1.

Accounting could later be owned (our own ledger). Do not. QuickBooks is what CPAs expect, the bank feeds already exist, and owning the ledger makes us responsible for every number on the tax return.

Native email: be the client, not the mail server

Outlook "allows Gmail" by being a client: the mailbox stays at Google and Outlook reads and sends through Google's protocols. That is exactly the model for Signoff, in two phases, and in neither phase do we run a mail server.

Phase 1: connectors. The owner connects Gmail or Microsoft 365 by OAuth. We write one internal mailbox interface (list threads, read thread, search, draft, send, label, attachments) with two adapters behind it: Gmail API and Microsoft Graph. The agent only ever sees the internal interface, so adding a third provider later is an adapter, not a redesign. A unified-mail vendor such as Nylas can replace the two adapters with one integration for a per-mailbox fee; worth it if we want to ship in weeks, not worth it at scale.

The real cost in Phase 1 is not code. Google treats mail-reading scopes as restricted and requires an annual third-party security assessment before an app can be used by the public; Microsoft requires publisher verification. Budget two to three months and a five-figure assessment fee for the Google side, and start it on day one. Until it clears, the app can run with a limited number of test users, which is fine for a private beta.

Sending from the owner's own address through their connector also means our deliverability is never on the line. Their domain's reputation carries their mail, as it should.

Phase 2: a mailbox on the company's domain, provisioned by us. When the company is formed, the agent offers a domain and a mailbox (hello@theircompany.com). We buy the domain through a registrar API, provision a Google Workspace or Microsoft 365 seat as a reseller, set the DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC) automatically, and connect it with the same adapter we already built. To the owner it is "native": the mailbox appeared inside Signoff, the agent reads and sends from it, and they never saw Gmail. To us it is a Gmail account with a reseller margin.

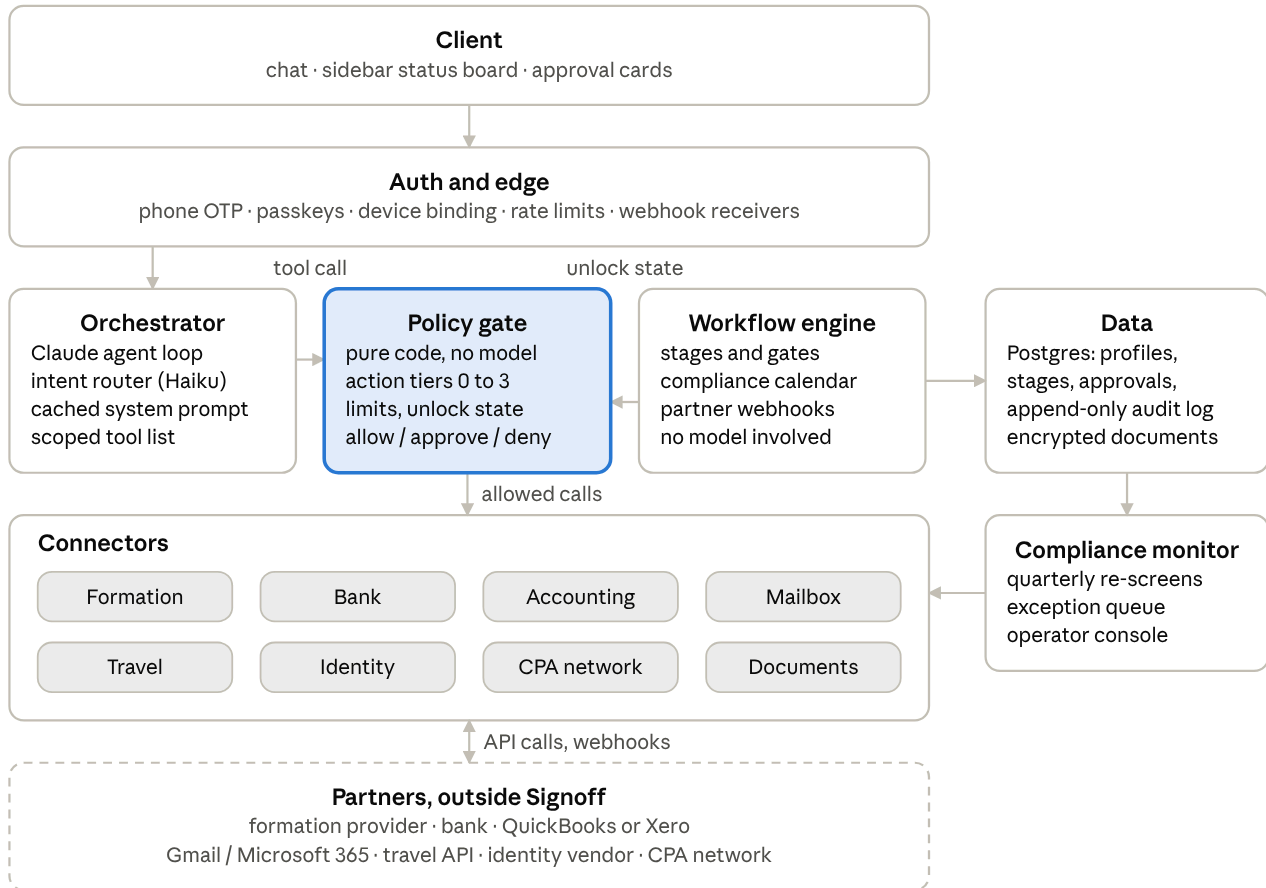
Why not build our own mail service: deliverability, spam filtering, abuse handling, blocklist management and storage are a full-time team and a permanent reputational risk, and the result would be worse than a \$7 Workspace seat. The only mail we should send from our own infrastructure is system mail (codes, receipts, reminders) through a transactional provider such as Postmark or SES, from a subdomain with its own DKIM so it can never touch the owner's reputation.

The client experience. Once two or more mailboxes are connected, Signoff shows a unified inbox beside the chat: one list, provider badges, and the agent's summaries and suggested replies inline. This is the part Outlook does and Gmail does not, and it is where "native" is felt, without owning a single mail server.

Architecture

The system is an agent loop wrapped in two deterministic layers. The model decides what to say and which tool it wants. The policy gate decides whether that tool may run and what approval it needs. The workflow engine decides what stage the business is in and therefore which tools exist at all. Everything that touches a partner goes through a connector with its own credentials, and every call is written to an audit log.

The model proposes; the policy gate and the owner decide



architecture · 9 components, partners outside the boundary

Every request flows top to bottom: the client talks only to the edge, the model only to the policy gate, and the gate only to connectors. Partners sit outside the dashed boundary and reach back in through webhooks, which the workflow engine turns into unlock state.

Layer by layer:

1. **Client.** A web app (React) with the chat, the sidebar status board and the approval cards. Mobile later, same API. The client never holds partner tokens; it holds a session bound to a device.
2. **Auth and edge.** Phone OTP for sign-in, device binding, passkeys as the strong factor for money movement, rate limiting, and the webhook receivers for partners.
3. **Orchestrator.** The Claude agent loop. The system prompt is assembled per turn from the business profile, the current stage, the module the owner is in, and the tool definitions that module exposes. A small routing model classifies intent first so most turns never see the full tool list. Prompt caching holds the stable prefix.

- 4. **Policy gate.** Pure code. Every tool call the model requests passes through it with the user id, company id, tool name, arguments and the intent class of the current turn. It returns allow, require-approval (which card, which factor) or deny. Limits (per-payment, per-day, new-payee delay), module unlock state and action tiers live here, not in the prompt.
- 5. **Workflow engine.** A durable state machine per company: stages, gates, scheduled checks and reminders. It emits the sidebar status, receives partner webhooks, and runs with no model involvement. Candidates: Temporal or Inngest, or a jobs table with a scheduler for the MVP.
- 6. **Connectors.** One adapter per partner behind a stable internal interface: formation, bank, accounting, mailbox, travel, identity, CPA network, documents. Tokens live in a vault with envelope encryption and are never passed to the model. Each adapter has idempotency keys and a webhook handler.
- 7. **Data.** Postgres for profiles, stages, approvals, calendar and the audit log; an encrypted object store for documents (certificate, EIN letter, operating agreement, invoices, returns); optional search index over the owner's mail and documents.
- 8. **Compliance monitor and admin console.** The scheduler that runs the periodic checks, an exception queue for the handful of cases a human must look at, and the operator view of any company's state and audit trail.
- 9. **Observability and metering.** Token and dollar cost per user per month, tool-call latency and failure rates, and partner webhook health. Metering feeds plan limits and the model-routing decision.

Security, step-up authentication and token control

The model never has authority. It proposes; the policy gate and the owner dispose. That one rule covers prompt injection, runaway agents and most of the fraud cases at once.

Action tiers. Every tool is assigned a tier at registration, and the tier decides what the gate requires.

Tier	Examples	What the gate requires
0 Read	Balances, transactions, email search, invoice status, calendar	Session only

Tier	Examples	What the gate requires
1 Reversible write	Draft an email, draft an invoice, categorise a transaction, generate a presentation	Session only; result shown in chat
2 Outward action	Send email, send invoice, book travel, submit a state filing, connect a new service	Approval card the owner taps
3 Money and control	Initiate a payment, order a card, change a spend limit, add a payee, change the phone number	Approval card plus a one-time code; above a threshold or for a new payee, a passkey and a cooling period; then the bank's own approval

Phone OTP, and what to add. SMS one-time codes are the right first factor for sign-in because every founder has a phone and nothing to install. They are the wrong sole factor for money movement, because SIM swaps and number-porting attacks are routine and target exactly this kind of account. Recommendation: SMS OTP for sign-in and for Tier 3 below a daily limit; a passkey (Face ID, Touch ID or Windows Hello, via WebAuthn) enrolled during onboarding and required for payments above the limit, for new payees and for any change to limits or the phone number. New payees get a 24-hour cooling period before the first payment can exceed a small amount. The approval card always shows payee, amount and memo, so what the owner approves is what gets sent.

Intent lock. Tier 3 tools are only visible to the model in a turn that the router classified as a money intent from the owner's own message. An instruction buried in an email or an invoice PDF cannot cause a payment, because in that turn the tool does not exist.

Secrets and data. Partner OAuth tokens live in a vault with envelope encryption and are used only by the connector layer; the model sees tool results, never credentials. We never collect SSNs, IDs for the bank, or ownership percentages. Tool results from untrusted sources (mail, attachments, web) are labelled as data in the prompt. All tool calls, approvals and codes are written to an append-only audit log with the hash of the prompt that produced them.

Token and cost control. The founder's instinct to limit which services the agent can touch is the main lever, and it does more than save money.

- Fixed tool catalogue, scoped by module and unlock state. A user in intake sees four tools, not forty. Fewer tools means a shorter prompt and fewer wrong calls.

- Deterministic flows do not use the model. Formation form filling, calendar reminders, approval cards, OTP and webhook handling are code.
- Two models. A small model (Claude Haiku 4.5) classifies intent and module for every message. The main model (Claude Opus 5.5, adaptive thinking at low effort for chat and higher for drafting) only runs when the turn needs reasoning or writing.
- Prompt caching. The system prompt and tool definitions are a stable prefix and are cached; only the conversation tail is billed at full rate.
- Caps. Each plan has a monthly token budget. At 80 percent the agent switches routine turns to the small model; at 100 percent it keeps the deterministic flows working and asks the owner to upgrade. Each turn has a maximum number of tool iterations, so the loop cannot run away.
- Payments are not a token problem. A payment turn is one classification, one draft, one card. Limiting payments is about risk, and it is done by the tier rules above, not by token budgets.

Business model and unit economics

Signoff charges once for formation and monthly for the agent, and earns a second margin from the partners it routes work to. The subscription should be priced against what it replaces (a bookkeeper’s hours, a formation service, a travel tool), not against the model cost, which is small.

Revenue line	Price	Notes
Formation package	\$249 plus state fees	Filing, registered agent for year one, operating agreement, EIN. Comparable services charge roughly \$300 to \$500 (approximate, from memory; verify).
Starter plan	\$39 per month	Chat agent, KYC and compliance calendar, bank view, email connectors, accounting sync, invoicing, presentations

Revenue line	Price	Notes
Pro plan	\$99 per month	Adds payment drafting, travel booking, CPA matching and the tax package, native mailbox on the company domain, a higher token budget
Bank partner referral	Per funded account, set by the partner agreement	Paid once; the integrated bank path is the only one that unlocks payments, which drives adoption
Travel margin	Percentage of bookings, set by the travel API agreement	Small per trip, recurring
Accounting affiliate	Set by the QuickBooks or Xero partner programme	Paid on new subscriptions we originate
CPA referral	Flat fee per engagement from the CPA	Paid when the CPA accepts; alternatively a package fee from the owner
Mailbox and domain reseller margin	Reseller discount on Workspace or Microsoft 365 seats, plus domain markup	Phase 2

Cost to serve. The figures below are estimates built from the Claude price list (Opus 5.5 at \$4 input and \$20 output per million tokens, cache reads at \$0.20, Haiku 4.5 at \$1 and \$5) and typical usage assumptions. They are approximate and should be replaced with metered numbers after the beta.

Cost item, per active user per month	Assumption	Approximate cost
Main model turns	150 turns; 6,000 cached prefix tokens, 3,000 fresh input, 800 output including thinking	\$4.40
Intent routing	150 small-model calls	\$0.30

Cost item, per active user per month	Assumption	Approximate cost
Background jobs (categorisation suggestions, mail summaries, reminders)	300 small-model calls	\$0.80
SMS one-time codes	About 20 codes	\$1.50
Identity and sanctions vendor	One check at signup amortised over a year, quarterly re-screen	\$0.50
Hosting, database, storage, monitoring	Shared	\$1.00
Total		\$8.50

At \$39 the Starter plan carries a gross margin near 78 percent before partner revenue; at \$99 Pro is above 90 percent. The formation package roughly covers acquisition cost for a founder who arrives through search. Partner revenue is upside, not the plan.

The cost line to watch is not tokens, it is people: identity exceptions, bank-application failures and CPA hand-offs that need a human. The architecture pushes all three into an exception queue so one operator can handle hundreds of companies, and that ratio is the real unit-economics question for the beta to answer.

Regulatory and risk register

The strategy is to stay a software company. Each row names the line we must not cross, and the design choice that keeps us on the right side of it. This is a founder's working list, not legal advice; a fintech lawyer should review it before launch.

Risk	What would make us a regulated or liable party	How Signoff stays clear
Money transmission	Holding, receiving or controlling customer funds, even briefly	We never touch funds. Payments are instructions sent to the owner's own bank under the owner's own credentials and approval; the bank executes. No wallets, no balances, no pass-through accounts.
Bank Secrecy Act and anti-money-laundering programme	Becoming a bank programme manager through embedded banking	Phase 1 and 2 are referral plus integration. Embedded banking (BaaS) is a deliberate later decision with a compliance officer hired first.
Unauthorised practice of law	Recommending an entity type or state as advice, drafting bespoke legal documents	Present options with plain-language facts and let the owner choose; use attorney-reviewed templates; offer a paid consult with a partner attorney for anything beyond the templates; clear disclaimers in the flow, not just the footer.
Tax preparer rules	Preparing or signing returns for a fee	We prepare the package from the books; the CPA prepares and signs. We never hold a PTIN or sign anything.
Sanctions (OFAC)	Serving a sanctioned person or entity	Screen at signup, quarterly, and on ownership changes; block on a hit; keep records.

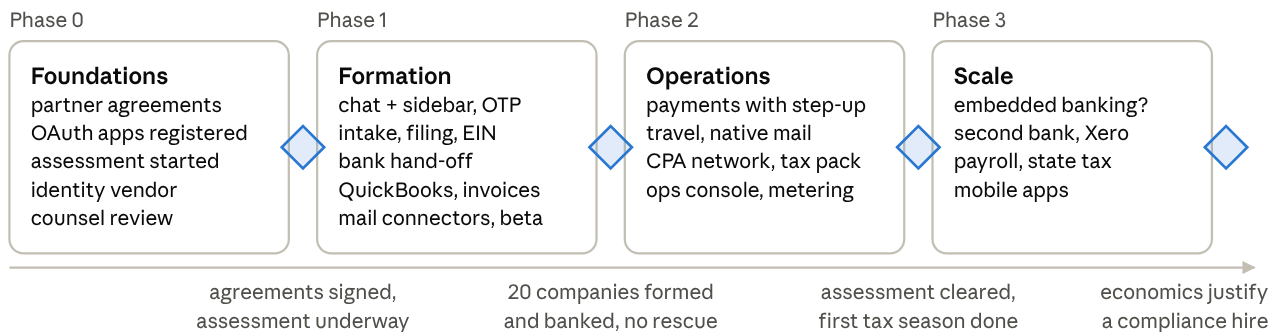
Risk	What would make us a regulated or liable party	How Signoff stays clear
Data protection	Storing identity documents, SSNs, mail contents	No SSNs or bank IDs ever; identity vendor holds the ID images; mail is processed and summarised, with raw content retained only as the owner configures; encryption at rest, deletion on request; a privacy policy that says exactly this.
Google and Microsoft platform rules	Using mail scopes without the required assessments	Start the restricted-scope assessment on day one; limit the beta to test users until it clears.
Payment fraud and account takeover	SIM swap, phished code, compromised session	Passkeys for large payments, cooling period for new payees, device binding, what-you-see-is-what-you-sign cards, plus the bank's own approval layer.
Prompt injection through mail or documents	An attacker's text causing an outward action	Intent lock on money tools, approval cards on all outward actions, untrusted content labelled as data.
Formation abuse	Bulk creation of shell companies	Light identity check before any filing; velocity limits per person and per card; manual review above a threshold.
Corporate Transparency Act	Beneficial-ownership reporting returning for domestic companies	Not built; a watch item on the calendar.

Risk	What would make us a regulated or liable party	How Signoff stays clear
Partner concentration	One bank, one formation provider, one accounting system	Stable internal interfaces so a second adapter is weeks, not a rewrite; bring-your-own-bank path from day one.
Model errors	A wrong deadline, a wrong amount	Deadlines come from the calendar engine, amounts from the owner's approval card, never from free text. The model drafts; code decides.

Roadmap

The lean path reaches a paying beta without a bank contract, a BaaS provider or outside capital. Each phase has a gate that must be true before the next one starts.

Four phases, each opened by a gate that must be true first



roadmap · 4 phases, 4 gates

Phases are in order, not to scale; each gate's criteria must be true before the next phase begins.

Phase 0, foundations. Formation partner agreement signed, a bank referral agreement signed, Google and Microsoft OAuth apps registered and the Google restricted-scope assessment started, identity vendor contracted, fintech counsel engaged for a one-time review of the risk register. Gate: the agreements exist and the assessment is underway.

Phase 1, guided formation and the chat shell. The chat with the five-item sidebar, phone OTP, intake and the allowed-activity screen, formation through the partner, EIN, document vault, bank hand-off, QuickBooks connection, Gmail and Microsoft connectors for a limited set of test users, invoicing, presentations, the compliance calendar. Gate: twenty companies formed and banked through the flow with no manual rescue.

Phase 2, operations. Payment drafting with OTP and passkey step-up and the bank's approval, travel booking with receipt capture, the native mailbox on the company domain, the CPA network and the tax package, the exception queue and operator console, metered plans. Gate: the Google assessment has cleared and the first tax season has been completed for the beta cohort.

Phase 3, scale decisions. Evaluate embedded banking with a sponsor bank, a second bank adapter, Xero, payroll partner, state tax registration partner, and mobile apps. Gate: the economics from Phase 2 justify a compliance hire.

What to build first, in order: the policy gate and workflow engine (the parts that are ours), then the formation adapter, then the bank hand-off, then QuickBooks. Email and travel can come last; they are the most commoditised and the easiest to replace.

Open decisions for the founder

- ☐ Name: Signoff, chosen 2026-10-03. It names the product's core mechanic (the agent prepares, the owner signs off) and a web check found no startup using it, only an enterprise approvals module from ActiveViam called Atoti Sign-Off. Still to do before any public use: a USPTO search in classes 9, 36 and 42 and a domain check (signoff.com is unlikely to be free; plan on getsignoff.com or signoff.app). The earlier placeholder XYZ was rejected because XYZ.COM LLC runs the .xyz registry and XYZ Venture Capital is an active investor. Runners-up if Signoff fails the trademark search: Duly, Standing, Footing, Hereby, Upstanding.
- ☐ Launch states: which two or three states we file in first (home state of the first customers, plus Delaware or Wyoming), and whether we support corporations at launch or LLCs only.
- ☐ Bank partner: one fintech bank with a referral programme and an API for document hand-off, account-open webhooks and payment initiation. This single choice shapes the Bank module.
- ☐ Formation partner versus filing directly with the state for the launch states. Direct filing is cheaper and more controllable but means we are the registered agent or must appoint one.

- ☐ Accept the recommendation to deliver formation documents to the owner and the bank at the same time, rather than withholding them.
- ☐ Accept passkeys as the strong factor for payments above a limit, with SMS OTP for sign-in and small payments.
- ☐ Pricing: confirm the formation package price and the two monthly tiers against two or three competitors' current list prices.
- ☐ Email approach: two adapters built in-house versus a unified-mail vendor for speed.
- ☐ Who reviews exceptions: the founder at first, then a part-time operator. Decide the hours and the service promise.
- ☐ Legal review: a fintech lawyer's one-time review of the risk register and the terms of service before the first paying customer.
- ☐ Age and eligibility: owners must be adults and US persons for the launch; decide how to handle a minor founder (a parent or guardian as the member or officer) because the bank will require it.